

North Korea



Area 46,450 sq miles
(120,540 sq km)
Population 24.5 million
Capital Pyongyang
Currency North Korean won
Official language Korean
Life expectancy 67 years



The Democratic People's Republic of Korea covers the mostly arid northern half of the Korean peninsula. North Korea is governed by a military regime that exerts total control over the lives of the population. A truce in 1953 ended the war with neighboring South Korea, though tensions continue to exist.

Japan



Area 145,883 sq miles
(377,835 sq km)
Population 126 million
Capital Tokyo
Currency Yen
Official language Japanese
Life expectancy 82 years



Japan is a constitutional monarchy with an emperor as its ceremonial head of state. It is the world's third-largest economy. Made up of four principal islands in the north Pacific (Hokkaido, Honshu, Shikoku, and Kyushu) and many smaller islands, Japan is prone to frequent earthquakes and tsunamis.

Laos



Area 91,428 sq miles
(236,800 sq km)
Population 6.3 million
Capital Vientiane
Currency New kip
Official language Lao
Life expectancy 64 years



The Lao People's Democratic Republic gained independence from France in 1953. This was followed by two decades of civil war. The Communist Lao People's Revolutionary Party (LPRP) has held power since 1975. There are more than 60 ethnic groups in Laos. Two-thirds of Laotians speak Lao, and many tribal dialects are also spoken.

South Korea



Area 38,032 sq miles
(98,480 sq km)
Population 48.4 million
Capital Seoul
Currency South Korean won
Official language Korean
Life expectancy 78 years



The Republic of Korea covers the southern half of the Korean peninsula. South Korea is one of Asia's most affluent nations—it is the world's leading shipbuilder and has a well-developed high-tech industry. Its strained relationship with neighboring North Korea remains a major concern.

Burma (Myanmar)



Area 261,970 sq miles
(678,500 sq km)
Population 48.3 million
Capital Nay Pyi Taw
Currency Kyat
Official language Burmese
Life expectancy 62 years



Burma, officially the Union of Myanmar, is a predominantly Buddhist country on the northeastern shores of the Indian Ocean. Ethnic conflicts rocked the nation following its independence from Britain in 1948. Burma was ruled by a repressive military regime from 1962 to 2010.



▲ MARKET IN JEONGSEON
Many South Koreans frequent the five-day markets that are held every week in Jeongseon in Kangwon Province.

Vietnam



Area 127,244 sq miles
(329,560 sq km)
Population 88.8 million
Capital Hanoi
Currency Dong
Official language Vietnamese
Life expectancy 71 years



The Socialist Republic of Vietnam lies on the eastern side of the Indochinese peninsula. The north and south of Vietnam, partitioned in 1954, were reunited only in 1976. It is now a single-party state ruled by the Communist Party. The most populated areas are along the Red and Mekong rivers.

Thailand



Area 198,456 sq miles
(514,000 sq km)
Population 69.5 million
Capital Bangkok
Currency Baht
Official language Thai
Life expectancy 70 years



The Kingdom of Thailand, formerly Siam, lies in the heart of Southeast Asia. Since 1932, it has been a constitutional monarchy, though with frequent military governments. Its capital, Bangkok, is the main center for commerce and industry. Tourism is a major sector, drawing large numbers of visitors from across the world.



▲ SPIRIT HOUSE
Most buildings in Laos have a spirit house—a shrine where offerings to the spirits can be left to elicit good fortune.